

A FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY GUIDE

The Christian Spiritual Reset

*A 3-Day Guided Retreat to Overcome Burnout,
Hear God Clearly, and Renew Your Faith*

Pastor Richmond Kobe

FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY

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Published by Faithful Path Community,
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Contact: info@faithfulpathcommunity.com

CHAPTER 11

Fasting, Food, Rest, and Physical Health

Elijah's story, which has followed us through this book, contains a detail that is easy to skip. Before God spoke to him, an angel woke him and said, "Arise and eat." Then, after he slept again, "Arise and eat, for the journey is too great for you" (1 Kings 19:5–7). God's first recorded response to Elijah's exhaustion was not correction or instruction. It was food, water, and sleep. Only afterwards came the journey, the mountain, and the whisper.

This chapter is about that care. It covers four things: whether to fast, what to eat, how to rest, and how to look after your body during the retreat. Christians sometimes treat the body as an obstacle to spiritual life. Scripture does not. **Psalm 139:14** receives embodied life with wonder: "I am fearfully and wonderfully made." Caring for the body is not separate from spiritual faithfulness, because we meet God as whole persons. The body you bring to the retreat is the only one you have.

A necessary word first. I am a pastor, not a physician. This chapter offers general pastoral guidance, not an assessment of whether any practice is safe for you. Health risks are not always obvious, and a general checklist cannot account for every condition, medication, age, or circumstance. Ordinary eating is the default for this retreat. If you wish to alter your food or fluid

intake, obtain advice from a qualified healthcare professional who knows your health history, before the retreat, not during it.

The whole chapter can be summarised in four lines:

- **Default:** eat normally, drink according to your usual health needs, and rest.
- **Optional:** consider food fasting only if it is already familiar to you and individually cleared.
- **Alternative:** practise non-food restraint from digital input, entertainment, or unnecessary speech.
- **Stop:** end any practice that causes concerning symptoms and seek appropriate help.

Fasting: optional, and not for everyone

Let me be clear at the start. This retreat does not require fasting. You can complete every session, with full benefit, while eating normally. For a retreat focused on burnout and restoration, my general pastoral recommendation is to eat normally and simply. You do not need physical hunger to make the retreat spiritually serious. Fasting is placed here rather than in the sessions precisely so that no one feels it is expected.

Scripture does treat fasting as a recognised practice. In **Matthew 6:16–18**, Jesus speaks of fasting as something his followers do and teaches them to do it without display. The passage does not establish a required duration or make fasting appropriate for every person and circumstance. The early church fasted before major decisions (Acts 13:2–3). But Scripture is equally clear that fasting is not a technique for extracting things from God. **Isaiah 58** rebukes people who abstain from food while continuing oppression and conflict. It teaches that religious self-denial is empty when separated from justice, generosity, humility, and care for the vulnerable.

Jesus' forty days in the wilderness are sometimes held up as a model. Chapter 3 said, and I repeat, that they are not. That was a unique period of preparation, and you are not being asked to imitate it.

Who should not fast without individual medical guidance. The following examples are not exhaustive, and being absent from the list does not prove that fasting is safe for you. Do not undertake a food fast without individual medical guidance if you are pregnant, breastfeeding, or trying to conceive; are under eighteen; are an older adult with frailty, reduced appetite, unintended weight loss, or medical advice to eat regularly; have diabetes or any condition affecting blood sugar; have a heart, kidney, liver, or gastrointestinal condition or any chronic illness; take regular medication, especially medication taken with food or affecting appetite, blood pressure, or blood sugar; are recovering from illness, surgery, or significant physical exhaustion; have a history of fainting, migraines, anaemia, or low blood pressure; or are uncertain about your nutritional needs.

Separately, and without exception: **this guide does not recommend food fasting for anyone with a current or past eating disorder or disordered-eating pattern.** Fasting can reawaken patterns that took a long time to escape, and it can do so under a spiritual disguise that makes it harder to recognise. Do not substitute another restrictive food plan under a different spiritual name. Follow your established meal plan and any treatment guidance. If the retreat's simplicity around food begins to feel like an invitation to restrict, or if food-related thoughts intensify, pause the retreat exercises and contact your treatment provider or support person. Nothing in this retreat is worth that risk.

If you are on either list, skip the rest of this section and go to "Food." There is no spiritual loss. Elijah did not fast; he was fed.

If you have been medically cleared and food fasting is already a healthy, established part of your spiritual practice, keep the retreat fast modest, familiar, and less intensive than your usual practice. Do not experiment with a new or extended fast while alone. Follow the plan discussed with your healthcare professional, maintain appropriate support, and stop if you become unwell. Some Christians practise what is now called a "Daniel fast," drawing loosely from Daniel 1 and Daniel 10 by temporarily eating simpler foods; Scripture itself does not prescribe a standard menu, and changing to a restrictive diet can still affect health and medication, so the same guidance applies.

Do not intentionally restrict water for this retreat. Follow your usual medically appropriate fluid intake, including any instructions given for heart, kidney, endocrine, or other conditions.

Stop the fast immediately if you feel dizzy, faint, confused, or shaky, if your heart races, if you develop a severe headache, or if you feel unwell in any way you cannot explain. Sit or lie down somewhere safe and follow any medical plan you have been given. Do not drive. If symptoms are severe, worsening, include fainting, chest pain, confusion, difficulty breathing, or seizure, or do not begin resolving, contact emergency services or seek urgent medical help. Do not remain alone while significantly unwell. There is no spiritual merit in pushing through a body that is telling you to stop.

Food fasting is not the only way to practise voluntary restraint, although Scripture normally uses "fasting" in relation to food. The digital boundary in Chapter 9, or temporary abstinence from entertainment, news, or unnecessary speech, may create the needed space without changing your nutrition. For many readers of this book, that is the wiser choice.

Food: simple, nourishing, and unhurried

For everyone, fasting or not, the goal for food on retreat is simple: eat well, eat simply, and do not make food a project.

Plan meals that need little preparation. Choose familiar foods that meet your dietary, allergy, medical, cultural, and medication needs, and make sure perishable items can be stored safely. Things you can assemble rather than cook are ideal. Do not use the retreat to begin a restrictive diet or experiment with unfamiliar foods. If meals are provided, receive them gratefully while communicating legitimate dietary, allergy, medical, or religious needs without embarrassment. The less time you spend in the kitchen, the more you have for the sessions, and the less likely food becomes a way of avoiding silence.

Eat enough. Some readers, in a spirit of simplicity, will under-eat on retreat without meaning to, and then wonder why they cannot concentrate by the second afternoon. Simplicity is about not fussing, not about going without. Maintain your ordinary, healthy eating pattern unless a qualified professional has advised otherwise, and eat enough to support concentration, movement, sleep, and any medication requirements.

Eat slowly, and if you can, eat without reading or listening to anything. A meal eaten in silence, with attention and thanks, is itself a small act of retreat. Jesus, after his resurrection, cooked breakfast on a beach for tired fishermen (John 21:9–13). Meals are part of how God cares for people. Let them be part of how he cares for you.

Two practical cautions. First, avoid making an abrupt, unnecessary change to your usual caffeine routine during the retreat; sudden changes can produce headaches and irritability that are easy to mistake for spiritual distress, though not every headache has that cause. If you intend to reduce caffeine, it may

be better to do so gradually beforehand or discuss it with a healthcare professional, particularly if headaches or migraines are a concern.

Second, alcohol is not part of this retreat, because it can impair judgement, attention, coordination, sleep, and mood. However, if you drink heavily or regularly and may be physically dependent, do not use the retreat to stop suddenly on your own. Alcohol withdrawal can be medically dangerous. Seek medical advice and supported treatment before changing your intake. The addiction guidance in Chapter 5 applies here.

Rest: sleep is not the enemy of prayer

Psalm 127:2 ends with a line that exhausted Christians need to hear: "he gives to his beloved sleep." Sleep is described as a gift, not an interruption. Elijah slept twice before God spoke. Jesus slept through a storm (Mark 4:38). The disciples' sleep in Gethsemane was a failure to remain watchful in a unique and solemn moment, yet Jesus' words also acknowledged their bodily weakness: "the spirit indeed is willing, but the flesh is weak" (Mark 14:38). We should not use that scene to dismiss spiritual attentiveness, but neither should we pretend bodily limits are unreal.

So sleep. If you arrive exhausted, as Chapter 6 said, you may spend a good part of Day 1 asleep, and that is fine. Do not set an alarm for five in the morning to prove your seriousness. Keep a sleep schedule that supports your health and responsibilities: wake naturally if that is appropriate for you, or set a gentle alarm consistent with your normal routine, medication, meals, and the retreat schedule. If you need a nap in the afternoon, take one; the three-day program in Part Four leaves room for it. Rest is not time stolen from the retreat. It is the retreat, or part of it.

Keep your normal routines around sleep. If you take prescribed medication for sleep, take it as usual. Do not use the retreat to try to fix your sleep, and do not use unfamiliar sleep aids. If you have a sleep condition, follow your usual care.

Movement: walk, do not train

The retreat includes walking, and several sessions suggest it. On the road to Emmaus, two disciples walked and talked through their grief, and Jesus joined them on the way (Luke 24:13–35). Some people find that gentle walking helps thoughts and emotions become easier to notice.

Movement is optional. Walk; do not train. This is not the time for a long run or a hard workout, particularly if you are fasting or exhausted. Gentle movement that keeps you within your ability and near help is what the retreat needs. Follow any restrictions from your healthcare professional, use mobility aids as needed, and do not walk alone in unsafe conditions. If you have mobility limitations, adapt the walking sessions to whatever movement is possible for you, or to sitting somewhere different, outdoors if you can. The point is a change of position and place, not distance.

Illness, injury, and knowing when to stop

If you become unwell during the retreat, treat it as you would at home. Rest, follow your established care plan, use prescribed or over-the-counter medication according to its directions, and seek professional advice if symptoms are unfamiliar, severe, or worsening. Do not spiritualise a fever. If you are ill enough that you would ordinarily stay in bed, stay in bed, and let the sessions wait. The retreat is not undone by a day of illness; it is simply paused, and you can resume or reschedule.

If you develop symptoms of a contagious illness at a shared property or retreat centre, notify the property or retreat leader,

avoid exposing others, and arrange appropriate care or an early return where it is safe to travel.

If you have an injury or a chronic condition that flares, follow your usual care and do not push through pain to complete a session. The sessions are offered, not assigned, and your body's limits are legitimate limits.

Before you turn the page

1. **Food plan.** The default for this retreat is ordinary, nourishing food. Will you follow your normal eating pattern? If you are considering a food fast, is it already a healthy, established practice for you, and have you obtained appropriate medical guidance? If either answer is no, choose a non- food form of restraint instead.
2. What will you eat, and how will you get it? Write a simple meal plan for each day.
3. What time will you allow yourself to sleep and wake? Write it down so you do not renegotiate it with yourself at five in the morning.
4. What movement, if any, will you include, and where is it safe?